Northstar Services

Customer Service Operations Handbook

Contact Handling, Call Standards, Identity Verification and Case Management

Document ID / Version	CS-OPS-001 | Version 3.2 | Effective 01 October 2026
Document owner	Customer Operations & Service Excellence
Applies to	Customer Service, Customer Success, Billing Support, Team Leads, Escalations
Classification	Internal Use

1. Purpose and Scope

This handbook defines the minimum operating standards for employees who handle customer contacts through telephone, email, web chat, social messaging, and service desks. It is designed to ensure that customers receive consistent, accurate, respectful, and auditable support regardless of the channel used.

The handbook applies to frontline representatives, senior representatives, team leaders, quality analysts, and any employee who communicates directly with customers. It covers the normal handling of a contact from identification and issue discovery through resolution, documentation, follow-up, and closure. It does not replace specialized procedures for complaints, billing disputes, refunds, privacy incidents, or service outages; those procedures are maintained in the relevant controlled documents.

2. Service Principles

Representatives must use the following principles in every customer interaction:

1. Accuracy before speed. Do not guess when a policy, account record, product rule, or system status is unknown.
2. Ownership. The employee receiving the request remains responsible for explaining the next step even when another team must complete the work.
3. One clear explanation. Avoid internal terminology and explain the customer's available options in plain language.
4. Document what matters. A future employee should be able to understand what the customer requested, what was verified, what was communicated, and what action remains.
5. Respect and neutrality. Do not blame another employee, department, vendor, or the customer.
6. Least privilege. Access only the customer information needed to perform the requested service.
7. No unauthorized promises. Representatives must not promise credits, refunds, delivery dates, technical fixes, or exceptions outside their authority.

3. Opening a Contact

For phone and chat contacts, the representative should greet the customer, identify Northstar Services, state their first name, and invite the customer to explain the reason for contacting support. For email, the response should acknowledge the customer's request and identify the case or reference number where one exists.

A representative should not immediately interrupt the customer with a list of questions. Allow the customer to provide the initial explanation, then summarize the issue: "To make sure I have understood

you correctly, you are contacting us because..." If the summary is incorrect, correct the understanding before taking action.

If the customer has already provided a case number, order number, invoice number, or service identifier, use that reference rather than requesting the same information again unless the information is necessary for verification.

4. Customer Identity Verification

Identity verification is required before disclosing account-specific information, changing protected account details, issuing certain refunds, cancelling services, or discussing payment information.

The representative must use the verification method configured for the channel. Approved methods may include authenticated portal status, one-time verification code, approved account questions, or a verified callback workflow. Do not use a customer's publicly available information, social-media profile, email signature, or caller ID as sufficient proof of identity.

Never request or record a full payment-card number, CVV, account password, authentication secret, or one-time passcode in a case note. If a customer volunteers such information, instruct them not to share it and record only that sensitive information was voluntarily disclosed; do not reproduce the value in the record.

If verification fails, explain that account-specific information cannot be disclosed until verification is completed. Do not reveal which answer was incorrect or provide hints that would allow a person to bypass the verification process.

5. Call and Chat Control Standards

Representatives should keep the interaction focused on the customer's stated objective. Place a customer on hold only when necessary to retrieve information, consult a controlled knowledge source, or contact another internal team. Before placing the customer on hold, explain why and ask permission where practical. Long holds should be replaced with a callback or scheduled follow-up when the workflow permits.

If a call is transferred, the receiving employee must be given a concise warm-transfer summary containing the customer's verified status, reason for contact, actions already completed, and outstanding question. Blind transfers should be avoided when the receiving queue is specialized.

If a customer becomes abusive, the representative should remain professional and issue one clear boundary: "I want to help, but I cannot continue the conversation while I am being threatened or personally insulted." If the behavior continues, the representative may end the interaction according to the abusive-contact procedure. Threats of physical harm, credible threats against employees, or statements indicating imminent danger must be escalated immediately to a supervisor and, where required by company policy, security or emergency services.

6. Product and Service Inquiries

When answering product questions, use the current approved product knowledge source rather than relying on memory. Confirm the customer's product, plan, region, and relevant version where these variables change the answer.

If the customer asks whether a feature is available, distinguish between "available," "available with conditions," "planned," and "not supported." Never present an internal roadmap as a committed delivery date. If the answer cannot be confirmed, create a follow-up case and state when the customer should expect an update.

For compatibility questions, capture the relevant model, operating environment, product version, and error message where applicable. A representative should not instruct a customer to disable security controls, delete production data, or perform destructive troubleshooting unless the approved procedure explicitly requires it.

7. Case Creation and Documentation

Create a case when the contact requires follow-up, another department's action, a complaint investigation, a billing adjustment, a service recovery action, or a response that cannot be completed during the current interaction.

Every case note must contain:
- Customer objective or issue.
- Verification status and method category, without secrets.
- Relevant product, order, subscription, or invoice reference.
- Material facts supplied by the customer.
- Checks performed by the representative.
- Actions completed.
- Information communicated to the customer.
- Next owner or queue.
- Customer-facing deadline or expected update date when applicable.

Use factual language. Write "Customer reports that the device stopped working after the update" rather than "Customer is angry because our update broke the device" unless the latter is an exact customer quote and the quote is necessary for an investigation.

8. Transfers, Callbacks and Ownership

A case should have one clear operational owner at any time. If a case moves between queues, the transferring employee must record why it moved and what the receiving team is expected to do.

Callbacks must include the preferred callback number or verified contact channel, acceptable callback window, reason for callback, and any information the next employee must have before contacting the customer. Do not promise a specific callback time unless the service has a supported scheduling mechanism.

If the customer contacts support again about an open case, the new representative should review the case before asking the customer to repeat information. Repeated contacts for the same unresolved issue should be linked to the existing case where possible.

9. Contact Closure

Before closing a contact, confirm whether the customer's primary question has been answered and whether any additional action is required. Summarize the resolution and any follow-up: what will happen, who is responsible, and when the customer should expect the next update.

Do not close a case simply because the customer has stopped responding during a live chat. Apply the channel-specific inactivity procedure. For asynchronous cases, use the approved reminder sequence before closure.

A case may be reopened when new information is received, when the original action failed, or when the customer disputes the stated resolution. Reopening should preserve the original history rather than creating an unrelated case.

10. Quality and Compliance Expectations

Supervisors and quality analysts evaluate contacts for verification, accuracy, policy adherence, communication quality, documentation quality, ownership, and appropriate escalation. A high customer-satisfaction score does not override a critical compliance failure.

Employees are expected to report knowledge-base errors, outdated procedures, recurring customer confusion, and system defects. If an approved article conflicts with a higher-priority policy, do not improvise. Follow the escalation route for policy conflicts and document the conflicting references.

Appendix A — Quick Decision Reference

Customer requests account-specific information	Verify identity using the approved channel method before disclosure.
Request exceeds employee authority	Do not promise approval; create or escalate the case with the required evidence.
Multiple customers report same failure	Check service status and escalate as a potential incident.
Customer disputes a charge	Verify invoice/transaction details before classifying the charge as incorrect.
Customer becomes abusive	Set a professional boundary; escalate or end the interaction according to the abusive-contact procedure.
Policy sources conflict	Do not improvise; follow the higher-priority controlled source and report the conflict.